

When Everyone Can Decide, Who Is Making the Judgement?

There is a subtle but important shift taking place in how organisations think about leadership. For much of the modern corporate era, the question of who should make a decision was largely answered by the organisational hierarchy. Authority flowed upwards and decisions flowed downwards. Executives established direction, managers translated that direction into action, and employees executed within defined boundaries. This model created clarity, accountability and control, but it also assumed that those at the top of the organisation were best positioned to make the most important decisions.

That assumption becomes increasingly difficult to sustain in an environment characterised by complexity, rapid technological change and distributed knowledge. The people closest to customers may understand emerging needs before executives see them in the data. Technical specialists may understand a risk better than the senior manager responsible for the budget. Frontline employees may recognise an operational problem long before it reaches an executive dashboard. At the same time, artificial intelligence is changing the economics of information itself. Increasingly, sophisticated analysis and recommendations can be generated wherever the relevant information exists.

It is within this context that the idea of the TEAL organisation becomes particularly interesting. Associated with Frédéric Laloux's work on organisational evolution, TEAL represents a move towards organisations characterised by self-management, wholeness and evolutionary purpose.

Rather than relying primarily on hierarchical authority, TEAL organisations seek to distribute decision-making closer to where knowledge and action reside. Rather than asking people to leave their personal identities and perspectives at the organisational door, they encourage greater wholeness. And rather than treating the organisation as a machine executing a predetermined strategy, they view it as a living system capable of sensing, adapting and evolving.

The attraction of this model is easy to understand. If complexity means that no single executive can possess all the knowledge required to make every important decision, then perhaps the organisation should not be designed around the assumption that they can. If the information required to make good decisions is distributed throughout the organisation, decision-making authority may need to be distributed as well. TEAL therefore represents more than simply a flatter organisational structure. It challenges a deeply embedded assumption about where intelligence and authority should reside.

But there is an important question beneath this proposition: ***if we distribute decision-making, how do we ensure that we distribute good judgement?***

This is where the relationship between TEAL and the Worldview LOA Framework becomes particularly interesting. TEAL addresses the organisational conditions within which decisions are made; Worldview LOA addresses the deeper evaluative structures through which people interpret those decisions. The distinction matters because decision-making is never simply a function of information. Two people can be presented with the same facts, the same analysis and even the same set of options, yet arrive at very different conclusions about what should be done. The difference lies partly in the way each person sees and evaluates the situation.

The Worldview LOA Framework conceptualises this evaluative position through Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency. Legitimacy concerns what an individual regards as right, credible, appropriate or worthy of trust. Obligation concerns what the individual believes ought to be done and the responsibilities and accountabilities associated with their position. Agency concerns what the individual believes they can influence, mobilise or change. These are not simply conscious questions asked at the end of a decision process. They form part of the worldview through which the situation is encountered in the first place.

This becomes particularly significant in a self-managing organisation. When authority is concentrated at the top, organisational rules, approval structures and managerial intervention can constrain how individual judgement affects organisational action. When authority is distributed, those mechanisms become less dominant. Individuals and teams are expected to interpret circumstances, evaluate alternatives and act with greater autonomy. In other words, TEAL increases the importance of the judgement exercised by people throughout the organisation.

This creates what might be called the **TEAL paradox**. The organisation becomes less dependent on hierarchy, but potentially more dependent on the worldview and judgement of the individuals who have been empowered to act. Giving someone authority to decide does not necessarily mean that

they have developed the capacity to examine the assumptions from which they are deciding. Empowerment can therefore accelerate decision-making without necessarily improving the quality of judgement. The hierarchy may have become flatter, but the underlying cognitive and evaluative patterns may remain unchanged.

This is where **Evaluative Reflexivity** becomes important. The Worldview LOA Framework does not simply ask people to recognise that they have a worldview; it provides a way of examining the evaluative position from which they are seeing and responding to a situation. The question becomes not only *What do I think?* but also *Why does this appear legitimate to me? What do I believe I am obligated to do? What do I believe I am capable of influencing?* These questions can expose tensions that would otherwise remain hidden beneath apparently rational decisions.

The Executive Sextant extends this idea into a process for moving from perception towards action. Its six stages—Observation, Appraisal, Angle of Appraisal, Judgement, Engagement and Behaviour—create a deliberate space between what is encountered and how the executive ultimately responds. Observation concerns what is actually present before interpretation takes over. Appraisal recognises the initial evaluation made through existing schemas. Angle of Appraisal then asks the executive to examine the perspective from which the situation is being viewed. Judgement integrates these considerations into a considered assessment, followed by Engagement and ultimately Behaviour.

The metaphor of the sextant is useful here. A navigator does not establish a course simply because a map is available. The navigator first establishes a position—a fix—from which the course can be determined. In much the same way, effective judgement requires an awareness of the evaluative position from which a situation is being interpreted. The importance of this becomes even greater when decision-making is distributed, because there may no longer be a senior executive positioned above every decision to provide the organisational "fix".

Consider a TEAL team deciding how to respond to a major customer problem. The team may have considerable autonomy, access to extensive data and perhaps an AI system capable of analysing customer behaviour, operational constraints and financial consequences. One possible response may appear optimal from the perspective of efficiency. Another may prioritise the long-term relationship with the customer. A third may protect employees from unsustainable operational demands. All three responses could be supported by credible evidence. The question is not simply which option has the most information behind it. The deeper question is what the team regards as legitimate, what it believes it is obligated to protect, and what it believes it has the agency to change.

This is also where the connection to AI becomes particularly powerful. My *AI and the Fix* insight argues that AI does not simply provide executives with better information; it increasingly becomes part of the process through which executives see the decision itself. A model can identify patterns, generate scenarios, challenge assumptions and recommend a course of action, but it cannot independently determine the evaluative position from which that recommendation should be

judged. The same principle applies to a TEAL organisation. AI may enable more people to access sophisticated analysis and make decisions with greater speed, but it does not remove the need for human judgement. In some respects, it makes that judgement more important because the apparent objectivity of the model can obscure the assumptions embedded in both the question and the answer.

This suggests that the future of leadership may involve a shift from centralised decision-making to distributed judgement. The leader's role is no longer primarily to possess the answer. Instead, leadership becomes increasingly concerned with creating the conditions in which people can make decisions responsibly, while developing the reflexivity required to understand the perspectives, assumptions and obligations shaping those decisions. In this sense, TEAL provides the organisational architecture for distributed authority, while Worldview LOA provides a conceptual architecture for understanding the human judgement exercised within that architecture.

The distinction is important. TEAL distributes authority while Worldview LOA develops awareness of the evaluative bearings behind that authority. The Executive Sextant then provides a disciplined process through which those bearings can inform movement from observation to behaviour. Together, these ideas suggest that the next evolution of organisational leadership may not be about removing hierarchy altogether, but about developing organisations in which people at every level are capable of taking responsibility for the quality of their own judgement.

The challenge, therefore, is not simply to create organisations where everyone has permission to decide. It is to create organisations where people understand how they are seeing before they decide what to do. In a world of distributed knowledge, distributed authority and increasingly intelligent machines, this may become one of the defining capabilities of leadership.

The question for the next generation of organisations may therefore be less about whether hierarchy survives and more about what replaces the judgement that hierarchy once supplied.

When everyone can decide, who is making the judgement?

And perhaps the answer begins with taking the fix before setting the course.